

Project DNA and Lineage Explained

Project: FSL framework. Appendix edition: v1.10. Four-Square Template v1.10. Explanatory only; no new project obligations.

1. One connected model, not another vocabulary

Formation: the method is not every project's genome

Think of FSL as stem-cell-like in one limited respect: a reusable starting pattern can be specialized for different work. FSL supplies a method for forming and maintaining an agreement. It does not arrive with every future business's commitments encoded inside it. A completed project FSL comes from its purpose, sources, boundaries and an appropriate adoption decision—not from renaming a blank template.

A new project forms its initial agreement. An existing system studies a reviewed present baseline, separates actual behavior from intended commitments, and governs forward. Neither needs invented history or compulsory iteration numbers. The biological comparison is a teaching device, not a scientific model of project management.

DNA: durable agreed intent

SPEC is the project's DNA in the sense of durable identity, purpose, commitments and boundaries. The adopted documents remain authoritative when people, agents, IDEs or skills change. Optional examples and background stay distinguishable from binding promises. Keep stable clause identity and explicit normative force; calling an explanation DNA does not make it a requirement.

The completed FSL is first inside SPEC and points to the authoritative supporting records. It is a compact entry point, not the whole repository or sufficient information to reproduce missing implementation. One authoritative home can coexist with identified reading copies and several coordinated repositories.

Expression, operation and understanding

SYSTEM is the working expression: code, services, operating work, instructions or produced documents. It shows what is delivered, not that every promise has been fulfilled. Different implementations can serve the same adopted outcome. Test the promised boundary rather than demanding identical internal form.

Skills supply operational intelligence beneath the agreement. A maintenance skill survives individual tasks by rereading the effective SPEC, asking better questions and proposing improvements. It may improve without changing intent. When an English skill is the actual product, its authoritative home may be SYSTEM; the analogy never overrides ownership by purpose.

MEMORY preserves continuity: rationale, decisions, limits and handover. Context helps understanding; it supplies no permission to override SPEC. **Evidence crosses all four responsibilities**, not a fifth square. A route is a declared path; a run is an actual journey; evidence records its scoped observations.

2. Replication preserves sources, not automatic success

Four events that should not be confused

Template adoption starts a project's own identity and approval process. Reusing FSL does not adopt another project's commitments.

Forking preserves identifiable source ancestry while the child states its owner, scope and adopted intent. A retained source history is not current decision authority. **Deployment** places selected artifacts in a target environment; identical source bytes do not establish target behavior. **Handover** transfers understanding and assigned responsibility; decision powers still need explicit delegation. A handover need not create a fork or a new release.

For any such event, ask in ordinary English: **What came from which baseline? What stays the same? What changes? Who may decide? What evidence still applies?** Use existing source references, snapshots, tasks and run records. No separate lineage registry or compulsory form is needed.

Sister cells: related expression, separate proof

Think of sister cells as related project expressions descended from one identified Project DNA baseline. One may be conservative, another experimental, another adapted to a different environment. Shared ancestry does not merge evidence or authority. Reuse source material and checks only within their applicable scope; re-establish changed environment, state or access facts. A successful candidate needs an explicit authorized promotion decision and recorded baseline; it never silently becomes its parent.

Selection and generations

The biology analogy is useful for variation and lineage, but project advancement is intentionally governed. Projects may choose selective, exploratory, comparative, bounded-random, mixed or fixed advancement in plain English. Randomness can create options; evidence can describe them; authority decides whether any option advances. A new generation is an adopted SPEC revision. Selecting an implementation within unchanged DNA can advance delivery without creating a DNA generation. Before promotion, review parent commitments, affected routes and evidence. Combining two variants creates a third candidate; their approvals and separate successes do not establish the combination.

Biology is an explanatory model, not an authority system.

Adaptation and adoption

An appendix explains. Errata corrects without changing intent. An adopted amendment changes intent. A proposal, copied instruction or improved skill does not amend SPEC by itself.

When expression and agreement diverge, first locate the problem. Repair a defect under unchanged intent; correct stale understanding from its source; seek evidence for an uncertain observation; propose adoption for a genuine intent change. Mere difference is not automatically drift, and a closed issue is not proof of resolution.

A release preserves a reviewed relationship

A release records an identified agreement and a compatible set of artifacts with scoped evidence. It is not a claim of universal viability, unlimited reliability or success in every environment. Preserve the released record and source ancestry; document effective changes separately. Reuse applicable evidence and recheck affected boundaries without either blind trust or ceremonial full retesting.

For new work, the recommended early learning goals remain tiny complete path, useful behavior, boundary/recovery and intended-use rehearsal. Existing projects need not reconstruct these goals. Local-first work, Actions OFF by default, scoped approval and shared call budgets remain unchanged. Copying a task or repository does not multiply an allowance or renew expired permission.

Where the analogy stops

Cells are not project repositories; regulatory biology is not an approval system. The analogy creates no new square, role, clause ID, test requirement or authority hierarchy. It neither enforces permissions nor runs a monitor. Projects may omit all biological vocabulary and retain the same method. **Documents govern. Skills maintain. Evidence verifies.**

FSL owns the method. The project owns the work.